

Checklist:

Team Objectives Checklist

1. Start with the right foundation

- ☐ Confirm the company is using or moving toward **empowered product teams**, not just feature teams
- ☐ Ensure teams are being given **problems to solve**, not only features to build
- ☐ Make sure leadership provides **strategic context**: mission, objectives, product vision, product principles, and product strategy
- ☐ Verify team topology is clear so the right teams are matched to the right problems

2. Define good objectives

- ☐ Write objectives as **customer or business problems to solve**
- ☐ Keep objectives **qualitative and outcome-oriented**
- ☐ Avoid phrasing objectives as deliverables, projects, or roadmap items
- ☐ Focus on a **small number of meaningful objectives**
- ☐ Check that objectives are important enough to matter strategically
- ☐ Allow room to refine wording after the team studies the problem

3. Define strong key results

- ☐ Define success using **business results/outcomes**, not activities or output
- ☐ Set **2 to 4 key results per objective**
- ☐ Include one primary success measure
- ☐ Add guardrail/backstop measures so progress in one area does not damage another
- ☐ Make sure key results are meaningful, not just easy to measure
- ☐ Let the team help determine the actual KPI targets and timing when appropriate

4. Give teams the context they need

- ☐ Explain the **ultimate goal** and why the problem matters

- ☐ Share enough context for teams to make good decisions independently
- ☐ Help teams understand implications, dependencies, and constraints
- ☐ Encourage teams to think through possible solutions before locking into one
- ☐ Invite teams to show interest in problems they are motivated to pursue

5. Assign objectives well

- ☐ Leadership explicitly decides **which teams work on which problems**
- ☐ Base assignments on both **product strategy** and **team topology**
- ☐ Use a mix of **top-down and bottom-up** input
- ☐ Let teams volunteer where possible, but optimize across the whole portfolio
- ☐ Ensure assignments cover the full set of company priorities
- ☐ Revisit assignments if the proposed scope or results do not match the business need

6. Set the right ambition level

- ☐ Tell teams how ambitious you want them to be
- ☐ Decide whether the objective is more like a **roof shot** or a **moon shot**
- ☐ Treat ambition as part of **portfolio risk management**
- ☐ Do not confuse ambition with effort or urgency
- ☐ Be explicit when multiple teams should attack the same problem at different risk levels

7. Handle commitments carefully

- ☐ Separate normal objectives from **high-integrity commitments**
- ☐ Use high-integrity commitments only when a date or deliverable truly matters
- ☐ Investigate commitments enough to judge feasibility, usability, value, and viability
- ☐ Track commitments independently from normal key results
- ☐ Raise risks early if a commitment is in danger
- ☐ Keep commitments the **exception**, not the rule

8. Enable collaboration where needed

- ☐ Allow **shared team objectives** when multiple teams should pursue the same objective together
- ☐ Allow **common objectives** when multiple teams should attack the same problem in different ways

- ☐ Make collaboration expectations explicit
- ☐ Ensure teams communicate to avoid conflicts and duplication
- ☐ Use collaboration, especially for large, difficult, cross-team problems

9. Align the broader organization

- ☐ Confirm that platform, marketing, sales, and other dependent teams are aligned
- ☐ Identify cross-team dependencies early
- ☐ Make sure supporting teams understand how their work contributes to the objective
- ☐ Check that leadership is managing the organization as a whole, not silo by silo

10. Account for real-world capacity

- ☐ Recognize that teams also have **keep-the-lights-on** work
- ☐ Estimate how much ongoing support, bugs, customer issues, and technical debt will consume capacity
- ☐ Adjust expectations if overhead is high
- ☐ Protect objective progress from being overwhelmed by operational work

11. Manage progress actively

- ☐ Hold weekly objective check-ins
- ☐ Review where the team is, what is next, and where help is needed
- ☐ Coach teams, especially less experienced ones
- ☐ Escalate important issues early
- ☐ Monitor dependencies continuously
- ☐ Ensure active management continues throughout the quarter

12. Build accountability the right way

- ☐ Hold teams accountable in proportion to the ambition level set
- ☐ Expect learning when ambitious bets fail
- ☐ Treat major misses like a constructive postmortem, not blame theater
- ☐ Review what the team could have surfaced earlier
- ☐ Review what leadership or management missed
- ☐ Improve the system, not just the team

13. Keep the overall process healthy

- ☐ Revisit or refresh objectives quarterly
- ☐ Change objectives mid-quarter only when necessary
- ☐ Maintain a back-and-forth between leaders and teams
- ☐ Keep leaders visibly involved; do not “set and forget.”
- ☐ Preserve both **empowerment and accountability**

Quick quality check

Before finalizing team objectives, ask:

- ☐ Are we assigning a **problem** rather than a feature?
- ☐ Does the team have the **context** to solve it well?
- ☐ Are the key results **outcome-based**?
- ☐ Is the **ambition level** explicit?
- ☐ Are dependencies and alignment covered?
- ☐ Have we allowed for operational load?
- ☐ Do we have a cadence for tracking and coaching?
- ☐ Is this empowering the team while keeping them accountable?